

Strategies for resilience: A qualitative analysis of rural community leaders' advice on disaster recovery

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ABSTRACT

Resilience refers to the capacity to withstand, overcome, or recover from serious threat, such as a natural disaster. In small towns, community leaders are intimately involved with their towns' response and recovery from a disaster and can see resilience processes, or their absence, virtually one person at a time. The authors interviewed 30 community leaders in two small towns along the Red River of the North, 7 to 8 years after a devastating flood. Responses to the question, "Based on your experience and observations (in your community), what advice would you give a similar community that was trying to recover from a major flood?" revealed a pattern of suggestions consistent with resilience strategies identified in the psychological literature. Specifically, the strategies of taking action, accepting help from others, engaging in self-discovery, maintaining a realistic long-term perspective, and fostering hope and optimism were mentioned repeatedly by the respondents. The authors also found rich sub-themes within each of these general strategies. These findings support the applicability of psychological resilience strategies to a community's disaster response and recovery processes.

Key words: resilience, recovery, leaders, rural

INTRODUCTION

Natural disasters such as floods stress communities in a number of ways. They may cause damage to private and public property and disrupt basic and necessary community services (eg, emergency services and electric power). How well a community recovers from a flood depends partially on the magnitude of disaster-related loss and the extent to which lost

resources can be replaced and remaining resources applied to the work of recovery and rebuilding.¹ Recovery from a major disaster may be particularly stressful for small rural communities because of the limited financial and personnel resources available.

Resilience involves the ability to "bounce back" from difficult experiences, such as a natural disaster, and to produce positive outcomes in spite of stressful circumstances.^{2,3} Psychological theorists and researchers have conceptualized resilience in various ways: a set of stress-protective factors and attributes, a process of developing skills and strategies to cope with adversity, and a motivational force that contributes to personal growth through adversity.⁴ Although the majority of studies in psychology on resilience have focused on individual characteristics and behaviors, the psychological concept of resilience can be extended to apply to a community's effort to recover from a disaster.⁵ In this article, we apply principles of resilience to understanding the responses of community leaders who were asked, following a 500-year flood experience, to give advice to other communities facing major disasters.

The American Psychological Association² (APA) published a list of 10 ways to build resilience, which includes both behavioral and cognitive strategies. The recommended behavioral tools include social support, goal setting, taking decisive action, and self-care. Cognitive strategies include various forms of cognitive reframing (ie, seeing the crisis as manageable, accepting change as a normal part of living, and taking a long-term perspective), discovery of one's strengths and weaknesses, building self-confidence, and fostering

hope and optimism. Decisions about which resilience strategies are used in a given situation are influenced by personal characteristics, learning history, and current environmental conditions. Overall, the process of building resilience requires persistent effort and flexibility in adapting to changing circumstances over time.²

Models of resilience that delineate specific factors and strategies provide a way of studying how individuals respond to stressful situations. We propose that these models may also provide a useful heuristic for understanding community disaster response and recovery efforts. The purpose of this study is to determine the extent to which community leaders' advice on how best to respond and recover from disaster reflects the resilience strategies described in the psychological literature.

METHODS

Community selection

This study is part of a larger project that is studying two US communities impacted by the 1997 Red River Flood. The Red River's watershed begins in southern Minnesota with its headwaters near the border communities of Wahpeton, ND, and Breckenridge, MN. The Red River then gently meanders north along the border between North Dakota and Minnesota, crosses the US-Canadian border, and then continues further north through the city of Winnipeg, Manitoba.

The Red River's route creates the Red River Valley, but it takes a perceptive eye to see anything resembling a valley in the basin's prairie flatland. When this otherwise modest river floods, it really floods, spreading across miles of farmland and into the hearts of many river-edge communities. With very few topographical features to stop its flooding waters, even small Red River floods can be major events, but the 1997 Red River Flood exceeded the River's pre-designated 500-year flood level. The 1997 flood triggered one of the largest ever, pre-Katrina city evacuations. Citizens of Grand Forks, ND, on the Red River's west bank and Grand Forks' sister city, East Grand Forks, MN, on the Red River's east bank had to "get out of town fast" when the flood waters topped their opposing levees. Considerable press attention—local to international—was given to the dramatic

evacuation of these twin cities with the penultimate attention grabber of a Presidential visit.

Still, there was much more to the story. The raging Red River ravished the entire river valley with many heroic flood battles occurring both south and north of the "Grand cities," but in smaller communities and with much less attention. We chose to focus our research efforts on the flood battles of two small towns, Breckenridge, MN, and Drayton, ND. Breckenridge is a community of nearly 4,000, whereas Drayton is just under 1,000. Both of the communities are on the Red River, but they had very dissimilar flood experiences. Despite a ferocious battle, much of Breckenridge was inundated by the 1997 flood. In contrast, Drayton stayed dry behind an improvised dike that engineers said would not work, but did. Selecting smaller communities such as Breckenridge and Drayton enabled us to identify and interview many, if not most, of the key community leaders in these towns' distinctive flood fights.

Interviewee selection

We interviewed 15 citizens in Breckenridge and another 15 in Drayton. With approval of the Institutional Review Board at North Dakota State University, Fargo, we constructed appropriate consent forms indicating to respondents our desire to talk about "community perceptions and values and how these relate to your town's recovery over the last several years from the 1997 flood." We said that the purpose of the study was "to help communities and agencies guide people through the recovery process . . ." Finally, we told interviewees that "you have been selected because we believe your experiences and perceptions will enhance our understanding of your community."

Our primary goal was to focus on individuals dealing with community recovery processes; therefore, we selected interviewees who were and are in positions that give them a community-wide perspective. We began by contacting individuals with visible leadership roles. We then expanded our list by asking at the end of each interview "Is there anyone else you know who we should interview as part of this project?" As a result of these efforts, we spoke with a variety of community leaders including city council members, active mem-

bers of various nonprofit organizations, business leaders, and religious leaders, as well as selected community citizens, outside the leadership structure, who were directly affected by the flood (eg, lost their home or business). Most participants were male, but we did find some gender diversity in the leadership structures of both communities (22 males/eight females).

Procedure

We followed a three-step recruitment process. First, we contacted potential interviewees by letter. Second, we made follow-up phone calls to determine interest and set times and places for interviews. Third, we met with each interviewee, obtained a signed informed consent form, and conducted the interview. The consent form included a request to tape record interviewees' comments. All participants agreed to have their interviews recorded digitally and/or on audiotape.

The interviews generally lasted for an hour and an half and were conducted in a variety of locations from homes, to business establishments, to the local cafe. The interview team included both the authors and three trained graduate student research assistants. We conducted these interviews throughout 2004 and 2005, roughly 7 to 8 years after the 1997 flood. Despite this considerable lapse of time, citizens told us that the flood was still a frequent topic of conversation because of the historic magnitude of the event and the ongoing community mitigation efforts triggered by the 1997 flood.

Questions

All interviews followed a structured guide with over 40 open-ended questions. Each question was read out loud and, if needed, followed by prompts, such as, "Could you tell me more?" The focal question for this study was the following: "Based on your experience and observations in Breckenridge/Drayton, what advice would you give a similar community that was trying to recover from a major flood?" This question was located near the end of the survey. It came after a series of questions requesting interviewees to reflect on their community's losses and gains associated with the flood. Thus, respondents had thoroughly discussed their own community's experiences by the time respondents were asked to give advice to others.

Coding

Each interview was transcribed and coded. For the aforementioned question, we began, as noted earlier, with an a priori coding scheme based on the 10 resilience strategies listed by APA.² To improve coding reliability, we reduced the 10 strategies to six categories by combining similar strategies together. Specifically, we combined two action-based strategies (ie, goal-setting and taking action toward goals) into a category labeled "taking action." We combined three cognitive reframing strategies (ie, seeing the crisis as manageable, accepting change as a normal part of living, and taking a long-term perspective) into one category which we labeled "taking a realistic perspective." We also combined building self-confidence and holding a hopeful, optimistic view of the future into a single category labeled "foster hope and optimism." Thus, our a priori categories consisted of the following resilience strategies: (1) take action; (2) accept support and help from others; (3) engage in self-discovery; (4) maintain a realistic perspective; and (5) foster hope and optimism. We found that these categories easily fit the data and covered virtually all of the interviewees' comments. However, we also initially included a sixth strategy from the APA list, self-care, that barely surfaced in respondents' comments—a point we will discuss at the conclusion of the article. For now, we turn to our results for our five combined APA resilience strategies.

RESULTS

Our question for this study was completely open ended without any suggestion that we were specifically looking for resilience strategies. After we applied the APA a priori coding, we more closely examined the comments coded in each general category and frequently found internal structures of meaning that we had not anticipated. These subthemes add considerable richness to our understanding of the more general resilience strategies (see Table 1).

The general strategies serve as the organizational framework for our presentation of the results later. We have included from seven to 17 illustrative quotes for each general strategy for a total of 53 transcript excerpts. The selected quotes come from 73 percent of

Table 1. Themes and subthemes

Take action	Accept support and help from others	Engage in self-discovery	Maintain a realistic perspective	Foster hope and optimism
Coordinate	Accept both material and task support	Know resources	Task patience	General optimism
Clean up	Accept emotional support	Face weaknesses	Emotional patience	Focused optimism
Do the paperwork	Avoid false pride	Appreciate vulnerability		
Listen to the experts	Trust help-givers	Strength from adversity		
Mitigate	Create a cooperative culture of help-giving/receiving. Offer real help			

our respondents, with each general strategy represented by six to 10 different respondents. However, we have not included a coded respondent number system to minimize the possibility that citizens of these small towns could somehow identify individuals across multiple quotes. The availability of such a wide variety of quotes and sources per strategy (even just illustrative quotes) reflects both the depth of the data behind each resilience strategy and the extent to which each strategy is salient across respondents.

Take action

One of the most frequent suggestions made by interviewees was to take action. The tone of these comments reflected a sense of urgency (ie, get in gear!). These comments focused on two action-related themes, coordinate and clean-up.

Coordinate. “Well, the first thing that I would tell them is that it’s absolutely essential that there be some kind of coordination for unmet needs.”

“... volunteer coordination is essential and somebody has to do it, somebody has to coordinate ... [and ask] what skills do we have and [what is] the best [way] to use these.”

Clean up. “Quickly clean up ... Because the grass starts getting greener ... I think that is the fastest way to recovery ...”

However, there is more to taking action than just the initiation of activity. Our respondents were concerned that future disaster leaders identify the right tasks to do. Taking the right action focused on three themes: do the paperwork, listen to the experts, and pursue mitigation projects.

Do the paperwork. “... jump through the hoops. If small business administration (SBA) says do this paper in triplicate, do it in triplicate. Do it twice in triplicate. Don’t give up ... there is a lot of paperwork ... but if you don’t do it, you’re not going to get the money.”

“Well, I will tell you ... when you have a flood, the more documentation you can put down to give to any government entity, whether it is Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA) or whatever, the better off you are. The more information you can put down—it will help you in the long run ... document, document. It’s called a paper trail and picture taking. If you can take pictures of what is happening, it’s good.”

Listen to the experts. “... get expert help on board.”

“I would also listen to the experts when they come in, the people who have been through it.”

Mitigate. “Always be on the lookout for changes or projects that are going to make you more

self-reliant—that are going to help you to take care of situations more easily. And don't be afraid to do them.”

“Any community that has a threat of flooding will have to come to grips with the fact that they are going to have to have some kind of device to control it.”

“... get that protection [eg, dikes] ... [to] where it doesn't happen again; that is where people want it.”

Overall, community leaders' advice to take action (coordinate and clean-up) and to be sure to take the right kind of action (do the paperwork, listen to the experts, and mitigate) suggest that resilience is a proactive, goal-directed process. Future leaders responding and recovering from disaster should avoid “paralysis of analysis” but carefully analyze what it is best to do, nevertheless.

Accept support and help from others

An often repeated theme in the literature on stress and resilience⁶ suggests that obtaining social support provides a critical buffer against stress and assists with recovery following stressful events. Our interviewees clearly wanted to send a message to other communities that they should reach out, make connections, and seek help.

Social support connects those in need to others who can provide, among other things, emotional comfort, material necessities, critical information, and task assistance.⁷ Most interviewees focused on importance of requesting material and task support, but others also highlighted the need for emotional support.

Accept both material and task support. “... be politically active in getting the support of their local representative or whatever ... to get the assistance from the government ...”

“Take all the help that you can get ... Whether it's from other communities, other people, or government.”

“Well, certainly take advantage of any grant funds that are available to you.”

“Take advantage of all the federal help you possibly can.”

Accept emotional support. “If there's counseling, go talk to them, if you need it, you know, use the help. So that's the advice.”

“After you had worked for 2-3 months, it was physically and emotionally draining ... you didn't have any more zip ... and they [outside helpers] got you jump started ... so take the help.”

“... Working together and trying to boost one another up and that kind of thing I guess [is what I would advise others to do].”

Four admonitions emerged regarding help seeking. First, do not let your pride get in the way. Second, take the risk of trusting others who offer help. Third, create a cooperative culture for exchanging help giving and receiving. Fourth, if you offer help, offer real help.

Avoid false pride. “... accept the help ... Some people have got a lot of pride ... “I don't need any help,” yes you do, take it!”

“... we saw other communities come in to help ... which embarrassed us ... We had kids that actually took the sandbags out of my yard ... We were sitting there worrying how we were going to get our sandbags off and ... [the bags disappeared].”

“[We came] ... to the realization that if we would had been willing to take advantage of some of those programs ... our buyout program could have started a year sooner. A lot of things could have happened a lot faster.”

Trust help-givers. “A person doesn't agree with these people when they come in, but, sometimes, you have to work with them. Our council did a really good job of telling them that is not a plan that will work for us in [our town], [so] what else can you do for us? They were more than happy to say we can figure something else out for you, we will work together. You don't let them come in and decide what is best for you and be done with it. They are people too. They are willing to work with you if you show them you are positive about something.”

Create a cooperative culture of help-giving/receiving. “[Remember] that they should stick together afterwards like they did during ... After the flood is over, you [are] a little less likely to show up and help ...”

“Stay united, work together.”

"Stick together."

"Involve as many people in the community as you can. Let everybody have a voice."

"Well, work together. Don't spend too much time pondering the decisions that others made."

Offer real help. "How about if I came in here with the church and the church came in and said what do you need? Well, what do you think I need? Well that's a nice question to ask, but if they'd ask . . . I'll tell you you're going to need the power washers the . . . etc, anything else, if you've got an idea let us know."

Thus, the tone of interviewees' advice was blunt—do you, as a community leader, have a problem asking for help? Well, get over it, and get over it, now! Similarly, these interviewers were blunt about the type of help communities will need. Although there was recognition of the importance of emotional help, the interviewees seemed to focus on material and task support. If, as noted earlier, taking action is seen as a key to recovery, then seeking action-related help is also perceived to be central to bouncing back.

Engage in self-discovery

Presumably, one can face future disasters better if one learns from past disasters. Embark on a path of self-discovery. "Know thyself," and you can deal more robustly with the future. At the individual level, this admonition suggests that you should identify which responses, strategies, and actions to eliminate or enhance, based on their effectiveness in meeting the challenges posed by the disaster. At the community level, "know thyself" seems to reflect a similar process of examining strengths and weaknesses in responding to the disaster.

Specifically, gaining self-knowledge at the community level is clearly a multidimensional endeavor. First, it involves identifying resources to address disaster-related needs. For example, one respondent commented on the role of a disaster-based, temporary Unmet Needs Committee in helping the community to identify resources that would be available for future disasters. Second, self-discovery involves facing a community's weaknesses. Third, part of self-discovery is gaining a philosophical appreciation for a community's

vulnerability before the forces of nature. Finally, respondents embraced the discovery of strength through adversity.

Know resources. "... is there an Unmet Needs Committee . . . now? No . . . [but] we have file drawers filled with how to start it up immediately."

Face weaknesses. "... first of all, evaluate where their weak spots are . . . we had a history of flooding, so we had identified all the issues . . ."

"Whether it is putting up a levee system or moving away from the river. It is such an overwhelming event that you have to take precautions from having the water inundate the land or the city because that is something that you probably will not recover from. Coming to grips with reality. If you have flood potential you better get serious quick."

Appreciate vulnerability. "It is hard to fight Mother Nature. Mother Nature rules and water is going to go where it really has to go . . . There is [sic] so many unknowns [that] . . . you really don't know what you should be ready for."

"Each natural disaster is different and unpredictable . . . Whoever thought in this flat land that the Coast Guard would take us up to our house in a boat?"

Strength from adversity. "The cool thing is that you really find out who your friends are and what your community is made of . . ."

"... If you really like the community, like the area, like the people, then it's worth staying there."

Overall, interviewees' comments about self-discovery suggest that it has two dimensions, practical and philosophical. The practical side involves learning about community resources and learning how to use those resources in disaster. The philosophical side involves learning the lessons of life that a disaster can teach. Ironically, this process of self-discovery is a double-edged sword for community resilience. Not only can you discover resources that you did not know you had and strength of character that you had never tested, but you may also discover that your well of

resources is shallow and that you are vulnerable to an extent you had never before appreciated.

Maintain a realistic perspective

Another type of advice that community leaders gave was to admonish other communities to have a realistic view of the long-term nature of disaster recovery. For the most part, this involved encouragement to be patient. Several interviewees focused on task patience, that is, the need to recognize how long it takes to complete recovery tasks. Others focused on emotional patience. To these interviewees, it was important to tell individuals in another community that there will be light at the end of the tunnel.

Task patience. “What I can tell you is that if you think it’s going to be over quickly, if you think you’re going to bounce back quickly, it’s not going to happen. It takes at least 5 months . . .”

“ . . . it takes a while to get everything like housing developments started and roads redone and dikes built and all that kind of stuff . . .”

“It’s been a long haul for us.”

“A small town with not very many people, but we are actually just to the point now, 8 years later, where we’re kind of resting a little bit from all of our projects.”

“Have some patience because it is going to take awhile to work through all the studies and grants and everything else. It is a slow process during the recovery period.”

“They have to be persistent.”

Emotional patience. “[Know that] you will get over it. You will survive.”

“I guess, just go on, to keep on . . .”

“Patience. Be patient.”

“Just hang in there and be patient and stuff like that.”

“ . . . eventually things do work out. It will get back to normal again. Stay strong. Don’t give up.”

“Physically it is quicker than emotionally because people were just spent after the physical work.”

Our community leaders learned firsthand how much time it takes and how much of an emotional toll

it can take to respond and recover from a disaster. Help giving in a rural setting requires tremendous patience.⁸ The resources are limited; formal help givers are few and far away; and most leaders personally know most victims. In addition, our leaders still have their own full-time jobs and family responsibilities to meet. Thus, our community leaders want future, small town leaders to be patient with the numerous demands that disasters will trigger.

Foster hope and optimism

Being patient with the task challenges and emotional lows of the present provides the cognitive and emotional space for hope to emerge. Many of our interviewees offered hope to fellow communities dealing with disaster. These statements of hope took several forms, from general optimism to focusing on specific projects and people, such as rebuilding a “new” town, engaging in mitigation efforts, and ultimately, trusting the wisdom and dedication of community leaders.

General optimism. “Look to the future . . .”

“ . . . It does get better.”

“It probably won’t take as long as you think to recover from what you have experienced.”

“There are always people out there that will tell you it cannot be done; you have to fight that off.”

Focused optimism. “ . . . what gets rebuilt can be better in many aspects. It really can be better.”

“You just hope and pray that it [mitigation] works. Just like this [flood] diversion, you just hope that it works.”

“Don’t give up hope . . . city officials may not, you may not always like them, they may give you a bad taste in your mouth after you get to see a different side of them during a disaster, but still they are trained to serve the public’s best interest. They will, they will make time . . .”

The aforementioned comments on hope are instructive in two respects. First, they suggest that hope can be both a general mindset and a focused belief in the potential value of specific projects and people. Second, and more surprising, the comments on hope are tepid at best. These interviewees are

discussing a disaster that happened 7 or more years earlier, but, there is as much angst in the above quotes as there is optimism. It's almost as if interviewees are telling others, "You should hope that things will be better—maybe, I think." In the face of a major disaster, hope appears to be a fragile emotion.

DISCUSSION

When asked to offer advice to another community facing disaster, our interviewees were ready to do so. Take action. Seek help. Discover your strengths and weaknesses. Be patient. Hope. These are the suggestions that come from the literature on resilience, and they are the suggestions that are clearly echoed by our interviewees.

So, what have we learned? First, these suggestions are not just platitudes. They come from people who have been on the front line of a major disaster. There is an emotional intensity in some of the comments similar to what one might hear in the voice of a parent pleading with a child to listen and learn life's lessons before it is too late.

Second, there is an inner richness to be found in these simple suggestions. Take action means something very specific to these interviewees. It means coordinate, clean-up, do the paperwork, listen to experts, and do it right. Seek help means set aside your pride and make connections. Self-discovery is both practical and philosophical—learn about your community's resources, learn about your community's vulnerability, and learn about your community's character. Be patient means be patient with everything, emotions, projects, and people. Hope means hope for the future, but also do not lose faith. It is the inner richness of these resilience suggestions that makes them come alive for communities facing disaster in the future.

Third, the emphasis that interviewees placed on taking action and seeking help provides a road map for outside experts who wish to offer help. Community leaders want help and appreciate the need for outside expertise. They also know that they have to do the paperwork necessary to get expert help—they have to jump through the hoops. These comments all suggest that outside experts will be welcomed and respected. However, it is also clear that outside experts are

expected to jump through some hoops as well. They need to respect how hard it is to ask for help. They also need to provide real help. If you are going to help, bring real resources and a willingness to take action yourself. An outsider's expertise will be respected if it is demonstrated rather than flaunted.

Fourth, the strategies of resilience are a means to an end. Taking decisive action, maintaining a realistic perspective, and other strategies are methods by which communities can restore damaged resources and protect against future loss. Many of the community leaders' comments had to do with obtaining knowledge and accessing funds to fuel recovery efforts. For example, the resilience strategy of accepting help is used to obtain expert advice on how to access emergency funds to repair homes and public structures, and the strategy of maintaining a realistic perspective (ie, having patience) is applied toward the goal of pursuing long-term mitigation projects.

Findings of this study fit well with the literature on community disaster recovery. In a landmark study, Rubin et al.⁹ studied communities recovering from major disasters, focusing specifically on decisions made by public officials and their impact on the recovery process. They identified three essential elements for timely and cost-effective community recovery: personal leadership, the ability to act, and knowledge of what to do. Our findings are consistent with those of Rubin and colleagues in several important ways. First, town leaders embraced the personal qualities of resilience and applied them to leadership of the community at large. Second, our respondents repeatedly emphasized the importance of taking action, including administrative action (eg, doing necessary paperwork) and obtaining needed resources (eg, federal assistance). Finally, community leaders recognized the need for information about how to respond to the disaster and sought expert advice to supplement their own experience in dealing with hazards such as flooding.

Future research needs to examine resilience and recovery over the long term. Research on long-term disaster effects supports the notion that replacing lost resources is important to recovery. Hobfoll et al.¹⁰ suggest that, in the wake of disaster, basic practical and physical needs must first be met to foster community

recovery and protect against long-term psychological distress. The emotional reactions of children and adults to disaster have been linked to several aspects of the recovery environment (eg, social support, financial assistance, and restoration of community services). Persistent disaster-related disruptions in home and work environments can have a negative impact on family functioning and may contribute to higher rates of depression, anxiety, anger, and suicidality.¹¹ Arata et al.¹² found significant emotional and physical distress among fishermen who had experienced deterioration in social relationships and persistent financial losses secondary to a catastrophic oil spill 6 years earlier. Mitigation efforts may serve to enhance personal and community resilience against future disaster events by protecting vital resources and enhancing community cohesion.¹⁰ Presumably, the resilience strategies offered by our community leaders, including taking action and seeking help, should promote the successful replacement of lost resources, the maintenance of social support linkages, and effective mitigation efforts. Our next research effort—already underway—will be to explore the 10-year impact of the flood on community citizens in Breckenridge through a random sample of respondents and the inclusion of multiple measures of net loss/gain from the 1997 flood as well as measures of current well being.

A final observation about the advice given by community leaders is the relative lack of recommendations for self-care. In fact, only two comments among the dozens collected across 30 interviews reflected this concept. Because we did not specifically ask about the use of each resilience strategy, we can only speculate about reasons why self-care was not emphasized. One possibility is that, for small towns facing a major flood, the demands of the crisis were too great to allow community leaders to take time for rest and relaxation. Community leaders were under pressure to work long and hard to protect the town against the flood threat and to aid citizens in the recovery process once the floodwaters had receded. In fact, had the leaders and residents of Drayton not engaged in a frantic, round-the-clock effort to construct a temporary dike, they might very well have lost their town to the floodwaters.

During a prolonged recovery process, community leaders are charged with planning, funding, and carrying out rebuilding and mitigation projects, in addition to the normal responsibilities of their offices. Community leaders and residents are forced to sacrifice personal wellbeing for the survival of the community under such circumstances. However, the neglect of self-care comes at a high cost. Many of the comments about accepting emotional support from others, having patience with the recovery process, and holding onto a seemingly fragile hope in the future reflect a sense of weariness brought about by the prolonged stress of disaster recovery. So, if we may conclude with our own bit of advice to community leaders facing disaster, please add self-care as much as realistically possible to the remaining resilience strategies advocated by those who have already faced disaster.

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